specified as having caused a serious deterioration in India's security environment by Prime Minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee in his May 1998 letter to US President Bill Clinton. In that letter, Vajpayee also noted that "an atmosphere of distrust persists" despite the improvement in India–China relations during the previous decade or so.[9] That there has not been much change in the Indian leadership's views about China since then is evident from Prime Minister Narendra Modi's references to China's expansionist tendencies[10] and his government's continuing to remain "conscious and watchful of the implication of China's increasing military profile in [the] immediate and extended neigh-bourhood, as well as the development of strategic infrastructure by China in the border areas" for Indian security.[11]

This chapter examines India's response to these persistent security concerns vis-à-vis China during the last seven decades. It divides the Indian response into four phases. From the establishment of the People's Republic in 1949 until the 1962 War, India sought to forge a cooperative relationship with China and in the process underbalanced against it. Following the shock of the 1962 war, India resorted to robust balancing in the form of both beefing up its military capabilities and seeking superpower support against China. A third phase began in the late 1980s, with India hedging against China in order to stabilise their competition, improve economic linkages, and coordinate diplomatic positions in multilateral institutions while at the same time continuing to practice internal balancing. Finally, there are clear signs of a fourth phase in the Indian response to China, marked by intensifying security linkages with America and its major Asian allies, thus opening the possibility of adding an external balancing element in the context of the growing power asymmetry vis-à-vis China.

A caveat is in order here. The spurt in recent years of Chinese economic, diplomatic, and military presence and